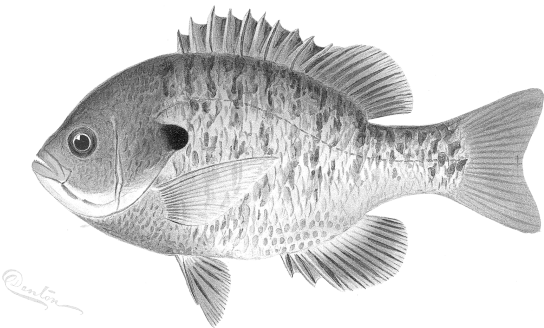


Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus

The best fish in the lake to learn on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

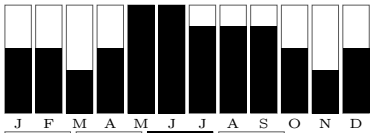
Tell it apart A solid black ear flap with no coloured margin, a dark smudge at the rear base of the soft dorsal fin, a small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fins. Compare with the pumpkinseed, which has an orange-red spot on the flap and wavy blue lines on the cheek.

Size here 6–8 in is a good fish; a 9 in bluegill is a genuine trophy and worth releasing so it keeps breeding.

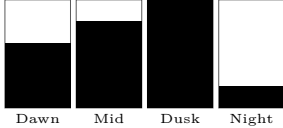
Spawn 67–70 °F, late May into June, in dense colonies of saucer-shaped beds on sand or gravel in 1–4 ft. You can see the beds from the boat and often smell them.

Eats Insect larvae, small crustaceans, snails. A small mouth means small baits.

Season



Time of day



Where

- Pine** Spots **6** (west bay) and **1** on the beds in June, then out to the deep weed edge at **5** — 12–18 ft — for the rest of the summer. Bluegill on Pine go deeper than most people expect.
- North** Spots **1** and **7**, and the weed flats generally. 4–10 ft.
- Winter** Basin edges and remaining green weed at 10–20 ft. Bays **6** on Pine, **1** on North.

How

- The rig** A slip bobber, a small split shot, and a size 8 or 10 hook, *see the slip bobber sheet*. Set the depth so the bait rides just above the weed tops.
- Bait** A piece of nightcrawler — not a whole one — a waxworm, a leaf worm, or a small leech. Bluegill have small mouths and will strip a big bait without ever getting hooked.
- Line** 4lb. Anything heavier telegraphs badly on a small float and costs you bites.
- With a child** This is the fish. Anchor over a bed in June, use a fixed bobber a foot or two deep, and expect constant action. Barbless or pinched barbs make unhooking fast and safe.

Fish the beds gently

Bedding bluegill are easy to catch and easy to strip out of a bay. Take a meal, not a cooler. The biggest males guard the beds, and removing them all is how a lake ends up full of stunted four-inch fish.

Worth knowing

There are two kinds of male	Large <i>parental</i> males build and guard the nests. Smaller <i>sneaker</i> males never build one — they mature years earlier, stay small, and dart into another male’s nest to fertilise eggs. The two strategies coexist permanently in every bluegill population.
Which is why big ones matter	Remove the large parental males from a bay and the population tilts toward small early-maturing fish. That is the mechanism behind a lake full of stunted four-inch bluegill — it is a consequence of harvest, not of overcrowding alone.
Colonial nesting	Beds are built in dense colonies, sometimes hundreds of saucers touching edge to edge in a few feet of water. You can see them from the boat, and on a calm June evening you can smell them.
Age	A 7 in bluegill in these lakes is commonly five to seven years old. A 9 in one may be ten. They are far older than their size suggests.
The pectoral fin is a giveaway	Long and pointed on a bluegill, short and rounded on a pumpkinseed. Useful when the ear flap is ambiguous on a hybrid.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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